

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN SAUDI ARABIA

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Concern for the environment in Saudi Arabia turns on a distinctive tension: this is a wealthy, closed kingdom, the world's largest oil exporter, undertaking some of the largest development projects the world has ever seen — vast flagship "**giga-projects**" marketed as models of sustainability — even as it pledges to plant ten billion trees and reach net zero, and even as those projects reshape deserts and coasts and, in at least one case, displaced the people who lived there, whose resisters met severe punishment. That tension — between the flagship developments and their green branding, between the oil economy and the green pledges, between the image projected to the world and the reality on the ground — is the distinctive ground of environmental effort here, because it is precisely the state's image-consciousness, its own stated green commitments, and the international attention its projects invite that offer the levers, in a country where open activism is dangerous. Saudi Arabia is a large, arid, and closed absolute monarchy of vast desert and long Red Sea coast, whose economy rests on oil, whose water comes overwhelmingly from the world's largest desalination effort, and whose Vision 2030 is remaking the country through enormous state-flagship projects. There is no landmark victory to point to. But the levers, resting on the state's own commitments and its image-consciousness, are real, and can be used with care.

In a closed, repressive kingdom where open activism is dangerous, the levers rest on the state's own image, its green commitments, and the international attention its projects invite — used with great care, strictly environmentally, and protecting anyone inside. The distinctive lever is the **giga-projects' green branding held to its own promise**: the flagship developments are marketed to the world as green, and can be scrutinised and held to that claim through the international attention they invite. The **Saudi Green Initiative and the net-zero pledge** set commitments the state can be held to, on its own terms. The **oil-superpower's footprint** invites international climate scrutiny. The **globally significant Red Sea coral** is a treasure the state itself claims to protect, defensible through marine protection and its international significance. The **water-security argument** is powerful: in a nation almost without fresh water, wholly dependent on the world's largest desalination effort — itself a marine harm — a project that strains water is self-defeating. And major projects have a formal **environmental assessment**. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. The giga-projects are top-down and state-driven, so they cannot be openly opposed but only scrutinised and held to their own claims. Oil is the economy's foundation, so the footprint is central. Desalination is essential to a nation almost without fresh water. The green initiative is real but set against a vast footprint. And the political space is closed and repressive: those who resisted a flagship project's displacement met severe punishment, so the work must run through international, technical, and protective channels, be kept strictly environmental, and shield anyone inside absolutely — never framed as political. And no landmark victory is to be won. So aim for what these tools can genuinely deliver — a flagship project scrutinised and held to its own green claims; the state held to its net-zero and green pledges; the Red Sea coral and the water defended; the international climate attention engaged — through the reputational, international, scientific, and technical channels, with great care, and protecting everyone.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You cannot openly oppose a state flagship project in a closed, repressive kingdom, and you must never endanger anyone inside. What you can do, with care, is hold the state to its own image and commitments: scrutinise the giga-projects against the green branding they are sold under; hold the state to its Saudi Green Initiative and net-zero pledges; invoke the international climate scrutiny the oil footprint invites; defend the Red Sea coral the state claims to protect; and press the water-security argument — all through international, scientific, and technical channels, kept strictly environmental, and protecting everyone inside.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Saudi Arabia is among the hardest and most closed settings in this guide, and honesty about that is the first and gravest discipline. The giga-projects are top-down and cannot be openly opposed; oil is the economy's foundation; the political space is closed and repressive, and those who resisted a flagship displacement met severe punishment. This is not a fight for open activism. It is careful, image- and commitment-based work through international and technical channels, whose realistic prize is a project scrutinised and held to its own claims, the state held to its green pledges, and the coral and water defended — while everyone inside is protected absolutely and the work kept strictly environmental.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

Power rests with the monarchy and the state, which drive the giga-projects from the top. The decisions a careful effort can influence run through image and accountability: the **international attention and reputation** the flagship projects invite; the **state's own green commitments** — the Saudi Green Initiative, the net-zero pledge — administered by its institutions; the **environmental assessment** bodies; and the **scientists and international frameworks** whose standards the state courts. Keep clear of the political red lines, and map which reputational or technical channel reaches a project before spending a week on it.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

A giga-project moves from the top, marketed to the world as green. You enter not by opposing it openly — which is dangerous — but by scrutinising it against its own green claims; by holding the state to its Saudi Green Initiative and net-zero pledges; by invoking the international climate and marine attention the project and the oil footprint invite; and through the environmental assessment. Enter through image, commitment, and international scrutiny, with great care, and never in a way that exposes anyone inside.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the branding: how a giga-project is sold as green, and where the reality departs from the claim. Follow the commitments: the Saudi Green Initiative and net-zero pledges the state has made. Follow the footprint: the oil economy and the international climate scrutiny it invites. Follow the coast and water: the Red Sea coral the state claims to protect, and the desalination the nation depends on. The leverage lies in the green claims, the international scrutiny, the coral and water, and the assessment.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Domestic oversight is weak and closed, and open activism is dangerous. The watchers a careful case engages are the international attention and reputation the giga-projects invite, the state's own green commitments, the environmental-assessment bodies, the scientists, and the international climate and marine frameworks whose standards the state courts. The state's image-consciousness makes these harder

to ignore than in a country indifferent to how it is seen.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No Saudi effort openly opposes or halts a state flagship project, and honesty requires saying so — the space is closed and repressive. What the careful, image-based tools can deliver is a project scrutinised and held to its own green claims, the state held to its pledges, and the coral and water defended. The single most decisive move is **holding the giga-projects to the green branding they are sold under, through the international attention they invite**, because an image-conscious state that markets its projects as sustainable is exposed when they are shown not to be, and because that scrutiny risks no one inside. The green branding held to promise is the distinctive lever; the Saudi Green Initiative and net-zero pledges the commitments; the coral, water, and footprint the concrete grounds; the international scrutiny the reach. The realistic prize is accountability to the state's own image, pursued safely.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the giga-project's footprint, the displacement, the coral or water damage, the oil footprint. **What green claim is it sold under?** — the sustainability branding to hold it to. **Which commitment does it strain?** — the Saudi Green Initiative, the net-zero pledge. **What international attention does it invite?** — the climate and marine scrutiny. **How is everyone inside protected?** — the overriding question. Pick the harm where the green claims, the coral or water, or the international scrutiny gives the clearest, safest handle.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case carefully, on image and commitment. **Layer one: the harm and the claim** — the giga-project's real footprint against the green branding it is sold under, documented with the science and the state's own materials. **Layer two: the commitment and the scrutiny** — the Saudi Green Initiative and net-zero pledges, the Red Sea coral the state claims to protect, the water-security case, and the international climate and marine attention. **Layer three: the channel and the safety** — which international, scientific, or reputational channel to engage, and the absolute discipline of keeping the work environmental, shielding anyone inside, and never touching the political red lines. A case built on the gap between the green branding and the reality, carried through international scrutiny, is one an image-conscious state cannot easily ignore — and one that can be pursued safely.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **harm record**: the giga-project's footprint, the coral or water damage, the oil footprint, the science. Gather the **claim record**: the green branding, the Saudi Green Initiative and net-zero pledges, the state's own sustainability materials. Gather the **coast and water record**: the Red Sea coral's significance, the desalination's marine harm, the water-security case. Gather the **channel record**: the international climate and marine frameworks, the scientists, the reputational avenues. Gather the **safety discipline**: confirm the work is environmental, shields anyone inside, and touches no political line.

STEP 3: BUILDING INTERNATIONAL AND TECHNICAL SUPPORT

The coalition here is international, scientific, and protective, because open domestic activism is dangerous. Build it from the **international climate and conservation bodies** whose attention the giga-projects invite; the **scientists and technical experts** who can document the coral, the water, and the footprint; the **reputational and media channels** that hold the green branding to account; and the **international frameworks** whose standards the state courts. Frame everything around the environmental gap between the branding and the reality, never around politics; protect anyone inside absolutely; and keep the work strictly environmental.

STEP 4: THE GREEN CLAIMS, THE COAST & THE INTERNATIONAL SCRUTINY — HOLDING THE STATE TO ITS OWN IMAGE

Set expectations honestly: the levers are real but constrained by a closed, repressive state, so the prize is scrutiny and accountability to the state's own image, not an open stop.

The Green Branding and the Commitments

The distinctive lever is the **giga-projects' green branding held to its own promise**, scrutinised through the international attention they invite, and the **Saudi Green Initiative and net-zero pledge**, commitments the state can be held to. Hold the flagship projects and the state to their own green word.

The Red Sea Coral and the Water

The **globally significant Red Sea coral** is a treasure the state itself claims to protect, defensible through marine protection and its international significance, and the **water-security argument** is powerful in a desalination-dependent nation whose brine is itself a marine harm. Defend the coral and press the water-security case.

The Oil Footprint and the International Scrutiny

The **oil-superpower's footprint** invites international climate scrutiny, and the **environmental assessment** is a formal gate. Pursued together — the green claims and commitments, the coral and water, and the footprint and international scrutiny — these levers hold the state to its own image, carefully, while protecting everyone inside.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case, always to image and commitment, and carefully. **For the international climate bodies:** here is a green-branded project whose footprint belies the claim. **For the marine and conservation bodies:** here is Red Sea coral the state claims to protect, at risk. **For the state's own commitments:** here is a project at odds with your Saudi Green Initiative and net-zero pledges. **For the water case:** here is a strain a desalination-dependent nation cannot afford. **For the world:** here is the gap between the image and the reality. **The golden rule:** hold the state to its own green image and commitments, ground everything in the coral, water, and footprint, keep it strictly environmental, protect anyone inside, and touch no political line.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media must be handled with the greatest care, and largely through international and reputational channels. Frame any attention around **the gap between the green branding and the reality**: a flagship project sold as sustainable whose footprint tells another story, and the coral and water at stake — never around politics, and never in a way that exposes anyone inside. Carry it through the international climate and conservation press and the reputational scrutiny the giga-projects invite. A few cautions govern everything: keep it strictly environmental; frame it on the state's own claims; protect anyone inside absolutely; and let the branding-versus-reality gap and the science carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message careful, image- and commitment-based, strictly environmental, and protective of everyone inside.

8A — To an international climate body: present the gap between a giga-project's green branding and its footprint.

8B — To a marine or conservation body: document the risk to the Red Sea coral the state claims to protect.

8C — On the state's commitments: show where a project departs from the Saudi Green Initiative and net-zero pledges.

8D — On the water-security case: set out the strain on a desalination-dependent nation, and the brine's marine harm.

8E — On the oil footprint: connect the project or economy to the international climate scrutiny it invites.

8F — To a scientific body: request the coral, water, or footprint evidence.

8G — To an international framework: engage the standards the state courts.

8H — To the international public: summarise the branding-versus-reality gap — strictly environmental, exposing no one inside.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: document the gap between a giga-project's green branding and its footprint, or the coral or water at stake; write the one-page case on the state's own claims. **The fastest-moving levers**: the green branding held to promise, the international climate and marine scrutiny, and the state's own commitments.

Emergency action: where a project harms the coral or strains the water, the marine and water-security cases and the international attention are the sharpest, safest handles. Throughout, keep it strictly environmental, shield anyone inside, and touch no political line.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is not merely tilted but closed and repressive. Recognise it plainly and adjust the aim — not an open stop, but a project scrutinised and held to its own green claims, the state held to its pledges, the coral and water defended. Lean on the levers the tilt cannot erase: the green branding held to promise, the international climate and marine scrutiny, the state's own commitments, the coral and water. And accept the

honest limits — the projects are top-down, oil is central, the space repressive — while still holding the state to its own image, carefully, and protecting everyone inside.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL REPRESSION — AND WHO IS AT RISK

Here the danger is not hidden corruption but a closed, repressive state where open activism is dangerous and those who resisted a flagship displacement met severe punishment. Respond only through the **careful, international, and image-based channels**: the green branding held to account, the state's own commitments, the coral and water, the international climate scrutiny. Never through open confrontation, and never touching the political red lines. **On safety and protection**: this note matters greatly here. Saudi Arabia is a closed and repressive state where open activism is dangerous, and those who resisted a flagship project's displacement met severe punishment. Favour the international, scientific, reputational, and technical channels over any open confrontation; protect anyone inside absolutely; keep the work strictly environmental; and be mindful that dissent framed as political can bring the gravest consequences. Protection is the governing rule.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel, carefully and largely through international channels. The documented gap between branding and reality feeds the international scrutiny, the state's-commitments case, and the coral and water arguments at once; the international, scientific, and reputational coalition organises safely alongside; any attention stays strictly environmental. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, document the harm and the gap from the green claims; **months two to six**, carry the case to the international climate and marine bodies, hold the state to its commitments, and defend the coral and water; **beyond**, sustain the reputational scrutiny. The core discipline: image- and commitment-based, internationally pressed, strictly environmental, and protective of everyone inside.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Saudi Arabia is among the hardest and most closed grounds in this guide, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim a state flagship project can be openly opposed or halted, or that the closed and repressive space allows open activism, or that a landmark victory exists — none of that is true, and those who resisted a flagship displacement met severe punishment. What it claims is real: that the giga-projects are marketed to the world as green and can be held to that promise through the international attention they invite; that the Saudi Green Initiative and net-zero pledge are commitments the state can be held to; that the oil footprint invites international climate scrutiny; that the globally significant Red Sea coral is a treasure the state itself claims to protect; and that in a desalination-dependent nation, a project that strains water is self-defeating. The levers work through image, commitment, and international scrutiny, and the prize is a project scrutinised and held to its own claims, the state held to its pledges, and the coral and water defended — not an open stop. For a wealthy, closed, image-conscious kingdom, that careful work — holding the state to its own green word, kept strictly environmental, and protecting everyone inside absolutely — is not a lesser ambition. It is the only responsible and effective one.